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Design Thinking

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The Power of User-Centered Design

I had the pleasure of working with an amazing team this time, where each of our abilities were cherished and heard. Thinking about how to help Dartmouth students carry their belongings around campus was a more than relevant topic for all of us, and this project really made us think outside the box. Compared to the previous projects, this one was very user-centered, where I ventured out into the Green, public places and small spaces to interview people, and test our prototypes. My most favorite part of the project was just working with the team, with Grace and Paola. They were very supportive of any crazy idea I added, and we shared a lot of laughter during the process. For example, when we were working on the final product on Tuesday, we went to the Massachusetts Hall and searched for the material for our banana hammock. This team work wasn't just a mere 'completing homework' but we shared interesting things about us, such as our favorite meal, which languages we speak, and about our personal lives. Everyone was flexible about team meeting times, and we more than followed our rules that we set in the beginning of the project. Even though Paola went to the game on Wednesday, she made sure she contributed equally to the project and I loved that.

The most difficult part of this project was brainstorming ideas for prototypes. We jumped from idea to idea, and it was later that we came to the conclusion that we would be working on helping people carry foods in their backpacks. Especially when we were working with the

crutches about how to help ease the meal process for the disabled, it was very hard to glue things and make them stable with the crutches. However, later on as we decided that this prototype would require more engineering skills, I'm glad that we were able to easily transition to another idea.

These are three learnings that I would like to carry with me: (1) working on a team project isn't just a mere of completing one assignment together, but collective skills together working on a meaningful problem, (2) working in 'chunks' like completing at least one part of the project every day is essential in keeping the track, (3) presentation and public speaking skills are essential 'face' of the prototype.

I believe every team member contributed equally with 33.3% each. Grace worked on completing the Foco cookie square container; I worked on the foco cookie guitar container; and Paola worked on the crutches respectively. However, there was definitely a mix of everyone jumping to help each other as well. I was glad to sew the banana hammock, and we all ventured to find the material for it together. While I was sewing, Paola and Grace worked on the presentation.